A BULLET JOURNAL TRADITION

The Daily Protocol

capture in the day. close the day at night.



Morning *two minutes, with coffee*

- date the page. write today's date before anything else
- copy over only what still deserves today. that is the whole edit
- note the mood tag honestly. it is data, not judgment

During the day *rapid log. do not decorate.*

- two columns: life, work. tasks, events, notes — all on the same line
- a task too big to finish today is hiding as a task. make it a project

> the signs, so tomorrow can read today:
> ✕ done → migrated — moved, with thought ↩ open loop

- never go to zero: one true thing logged makes today non-zero

Evening shutdown *five minutes. the day cannot close itself.*



- mark what happened: done, moved, dropped. no unmarked tasks survive the day
- what do I want more of? what do I want less of?
- what is one thing I'm proud of? write it even if it's small
- what can I improve tomorrow? one thing. then close the book

the daily log is not a to-do list.

it is the record the rest of the system reads.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Weekly Review

the difference between a journal and an organized life.

Look back

fifteen minutes. Friday afternoon or Sunday morning.

- read this week's daily pages slowly. the dots are a rereading device
- every open task: done, dead, or next week. decide now, in ink
- migrated three times already? it is telling you something. listen: delete, delegate, or schedule it

more · continue · less

three lines on the week. not a verdict, just a course correction.



Check in

two lines, honest



- head: good, or not good? name what is in it
- mood: alright, or not alright? it is allowed to not be alright
- people and meals: who did I actually see? who did I only think about?

Look ahead

set the week up to succeed



- calendar first: appointments before intentions. lies fit in free space
- the week's big three. everything else is weather
- leave one blank line a day. a plan with no slack is a guilt machine

review the week, or the week reviews you.

skip it once and the backlog does not wait; it just hides.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

A BULLET JOURNAL TRADITION

The Monthly Ritual

one hour at the month's edge. last weekend, not next monday.

Harvest

the weeklies are the crop; this is the barn

- reread the monthly reviews' worth of weekly pages. five minutes, no fixing
- tally what actually happened: walks, games, dinners, quiet days
- recurring insights get a collection page. a margin note is a thought with no address

Write the Focus

one line. the whole month fits on it or it is not the focus.

Focus: _____

one sentence on what the month is for. everything else is weather.

- under it: a few proud-of lines. evidence, not aspiration
- name one thing to be proud of next month. pride is a strategy too

Edit

the monthly migration, miniature

- open projects: would it make you, or those you love, happy?
- carry only what still matters into next month's log. let the rest compost
- check the calendar horizon: birthdays, visits, the impossible tuesdays



Widen

once a month, see further

- one question, rotating: what am I avoiding? what wants less of me?
- every few months: the 1 / 5 / 10 year horizons. last and next, in writing

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a month without reflection is just thirty more days.

the review is where the journal starts working for you.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Seasonal Check-in

four times a year, on the solstice or near enough.

The seasons nest

days feed weeks, weeks feed months, months feed the season

- read the three monthly focuses back to back. the season announces itself
- what grew? what was planted and never came up? that is data, not failure

SPRING	SUMMER	AUTUMN	WINTER
plant	*grow*	*harvest*	*rest*
mar · apr · may	jun · jul · aug	sep · oct · nov	dec · jan · feb

Four questions

one line each. no essays.

- body, work, people, play: which one is starving?
- what am I still carrying that belongs to a previous season?
- what does this season need to be true for the year to work?
- what are the three big rocks? three, not thirty

Nest the plans

the season feeds the year; the months feed the season

- write the season's intention on its first monthly page
- schedule the season's one real break before the busy fills in



you are gardening, not manufacturing.

seasons have weather. plans should too.

as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Quarterly Review

work, zoomed out. the seasonal page's ledger-keeping twin.

Close the books

one hour. you cannot roll a dirty ledger forward

- reread the quarter's three monthly focuses together. did the quarter have a shape?
- what shipped? name every one. a quarter that only spent is not a quarter that worked
- what stalled? stalled is not failed. decide: restart, rescope, or release it



Tend the systems

the tooling is a garden now. walk it



- one slow mind sweep. capture only. no filing, no deciding
- the hygiene reports: anything memory forgot that they list is fine. anything memory remembers that they do not list is a hole in the tooling. file the hole
- unmerged branches, open PRs, forgotten worktrees: every loop should live in the tooling or on this page. none in the head
- what did the agents do this quarter? what is still me, by hand? decide which of those changes next quarter

every project gets two checklists: start and end.

the end one is the one nobody writes. what will we miss when it is gone, and what will we tell people about it? write both, first.



Set the rocks

three. the rest is weather



- three big rocks for the quarter: not thirty. the page would overflow anyway
- each rock gets a first visible step today. a rock with no first step is a wish
- schedule the one real break before the busy schedules you

the ledger is for you, not for your manager.

ship small things. count them. tell the story of the quarter in one line.

as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

A BULLET JOURNAL TRADITION

The Yearly Migration

start a new notebook. keep only what still matters.



old book → new book

December *edit down before you move*

- close open loops: finish them or kill them
- what slipped this year? let it go. do not chase it into January
- weed lists and projects: will it still make you, or those you love, happy?
- scope out next year's notebook so it is ready on the 1st

January 1 *the changing of the guard*

- sit with the old book: what worked, what didn't, what did I learn?
- break in the new spine first. gently
- migrate only what still matters: edited lists and collections, not everything
- or thread it instead of copying:

> 7.125 = notebook 7, page 125
> number your old books, then point at them



- set up January's monthly log; carry over only lingering tasks
- write start and end dates on the old book's fore-edge
- thank it. add it to the shelf



one rule: always simplify

be less busy so you can be more productive.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Birthday Review

the yearly migration changes notebooks. this one changes you.

The audit

an hour. honest answers only. no one else reads this

- describe your life to a stranger. who are you, right now, this year?
- what is working? say it out loud, then write it down
- what is not? no fixing today. just naming
- what am I grateful for? people first, things second

working	not working
more of	less of

the chapter log:
four cells on the year
left side looks back,
right side aims forward



The ranking

the values tournament, run again

- re-rank your values. top five, in order. last year's order is allowed to be wrong
- check the gap: does this year's calendar match last year's list?

The horizon

and then the party



- one line each: the year ahead at 1 year, 5 years, 10 years
- who have I lost touch with? one message today, not someday
- then the dinner. it is part of the ritual. the ritual counts

you are not behind. you are on year N.

the audit is a check-engine light, not a verdict.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

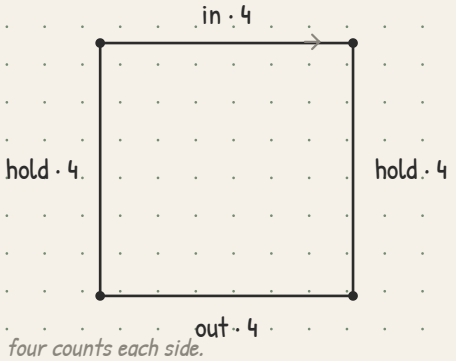
A FIELD REFERENCE · KEEP IT NEAR

The Pausing Page

four ways to ride out the wave before it rides you.

Box breath

when the thoughts are spinning



four counts each side.
trace it with a finger if that helps.

5 · 4 · 3 · 2 · 1

when the body is ahead of you

5	see	name five things you can see
4	touch	four things you can feel
3	hear	three sounds, near or far
2	smell	two smells, or two you love
1	taste	one taste, or one slow sip

feet on the floor counts.
end when the tide has turned. no prize for speed.

Body scan

when you cannot name the feeling

- jaw — clenched?
- shoulders — up by the ears?
- chest — tight or clutching?
- stomach — churning?
- hands — fists?

notice it, breathe into it once, move on.
naming it is the whole technique.

Straw breath

when you need the fastest brake

out twice as long as in.

that ratio is the switch:
it is the vagus nerve's dimmer.

in through the nose ☐ 4

out through a straw ☐ 8



in a hurry: the physiological sigh —
two quick inhales, one long sigh out.
settling: 4 in, 7 hold, 8 out.

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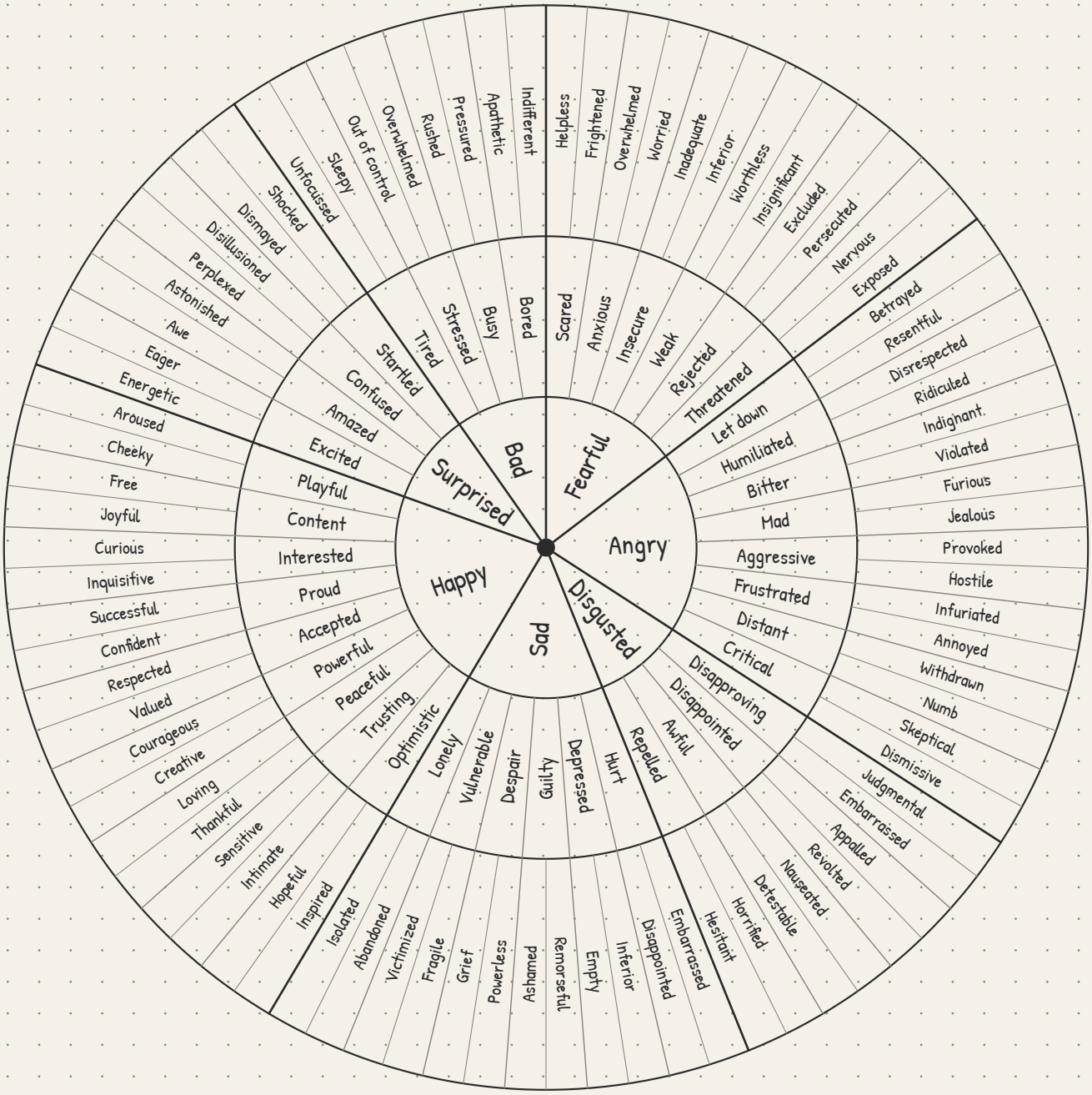
you are not the wave. you are the surfer.

catch it early — the practice itself builds the skill.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Feelings Wheel

a map of the weather inside; find the word that fits.



start near the center, follow a feeling outward until a word fits. name it and the storm loses rank.

name it to tame it.

vague feelings are a weather forecast with no map.
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.

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The Mood Meter

two questions, one cell: how much energy, and does it feel good?

high energy

Enraged	Stressed	Shocked	Surprised	Festive	Ecstatic
Fuming	Angry	Restless	Energized	Optimistic	Excited
Repulsed	Worried	Uneasy	Focused	Hopeful	Blissful
Disgusted	Down	Apathetic	At ease	Content	Fulfilled
Miserable	Lonely	Tired	Relaxed	Restful	Balanced
Despair	Desolate	Drained	Sleepy	Tranquil	Serene

low energy

unpleasant — pleasant

How to use

ten seconds

- energy first: is the body revved up or slowed down? that picks the top or bottom half
- then the sign: pleasant or unpleasant? that picks the side. land on the nearest word
- want a finer word? take it to the feelings wheel and follow it outward

where am i, right now?

a cell is a place on a map, not a verdict on the day..
as with all things bullet journal: do what works for you.